

UX Research Portfolio

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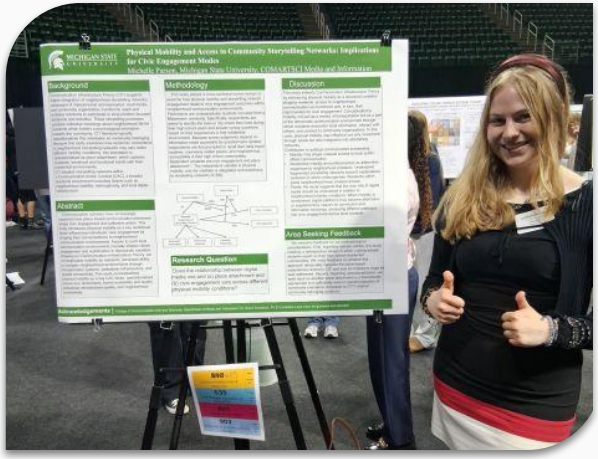
About me

I’m a UX researcher with a focus on uncovering core user needs through in-depth interviews and empirically measuring usability. I live in West Bloomfield, MI.

I was trained at Michigan State University’s Information Science program in human-centered technology. I had extensive training in media and information research methods. I’ve translated my findings into an Award Winning prototype, grounded in user research (link).

My work sits at the intersection of qualitative research and systematic design. I'm drawn to complex problems that sit in between interdependent societal systems, and how to design these systems with humans who use and live within them in mind to better serve underrepresented communities.

Previously a Coach and Group Fitness Class Leader, my experience personalizing experiences for people has equipped me to design with a human-centered approach. Currently open to new collaborations.



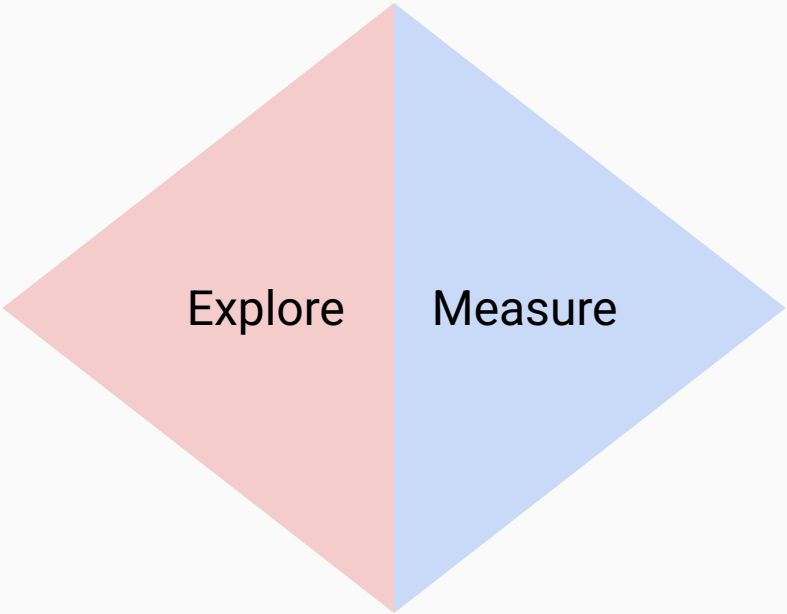
My research presentation - a lovely opportunity to speak about my research, and use feedback to iterate my design and approaches

My research approach

I use qualitative research to explore and define the problem space.

I use quantitative research to measure and validate the defined problem.

I have combined these phases into single studies and staggered them across research roadmaps.



A few driving philosophies

Focus on user behaviors, avoid asking what users prefer.

People are experts in their own lives. Products should be designed to fit within the dense context of everyday life.

Start with the research question and *then* choose the method for the most impactful results.

Quantitative research will show *what* and *how much*; qualitative research will show *why*.

My Process

A constant feedback loop rooted in iteration and human-centered inquiry.

Step 01

Research
Understanding the problem and the people facing it, gathering relevant context and data.

Step 02

Problem Definition
After getting more context, going a step further to properly frame the problem.

Step 03

User Journey Mapping
Before design exploration, taking the time to map the user's journey and stories.

Step 04

Design Exploration
Exploring various design solutions and seeking feedback from relevant stakeholders.

Step 05

Usability Testing
Carrying out usability testing with users to locate pain points and use feedback for iteration.

Step 06

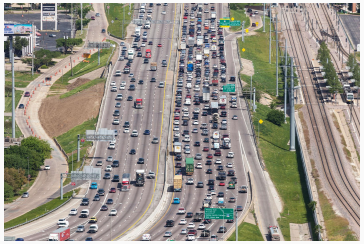
Hand-off & Monitoring
Handing off all design-related assets to developers and monitoring relevant performance metrics.

Case Study: From Research to Product - Designing for Community Access in Mobility-Limited Neighborhoods

Part 1a: The Problem

Access to community isn't just about willingness, it's about the physical ability to reach the places where community happens.

When you can't easily move through your neighborhood, your social network shrink, and with them, your sense of belonging and civic engagement. Existing social platforms ignore this mobility constraint entirely.



Example of Mobility-Limiting infrastructure



Example of Mobility-encouraging infrastructure
(Michigan State University campus)

Part 1b: Methodology
Quantitative Findings (*What* and *How Many*?)

Note: Data cleanup is still in progress for this project

Higher physical mobility is positively associated with stronger integration into local storytelling networks.

Survey drew on Communication Infrastructure Theory; measured physical mobility, Integrated Connectedness to Storytelling Networks (ICSN), place attachment, civic engagement.

N = 283 respondents

1. Finding my bus station /metro station is not easy
2. My bus stop is not close enough to walk to
3. I feel unsafe because of traffic condition
4. I feel stressed because of traffic condition

^ Sample Mobility Accessibility Survey Questions (on 7-point Likert scale: Strongly disagree, Disagree, Somewhat disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Somewhat agree, Agree, Strongly agree).

Part 1b: Methodology
Qualitative Findings (*Why*?)

Car-dependent residents reported restricted access to community spaces, and many turned to digital channels as an alternative coping mechanism.

“If I do see someone in person it’s only for five minutes because everyone's always shopping in a rush, and if I don’t see them I usually scroll on FaceBook for updates on how everyone’s doing.”

- Anonymous quote from an individual interview session

This insight directly informed the design solution.

Part 1c: The Insight

When physical mobility is constrained, digital platforms become the alternative space for connection. The design should be a **bridge to community**, not a replacement for it.



Caption: image of people gathered in community space

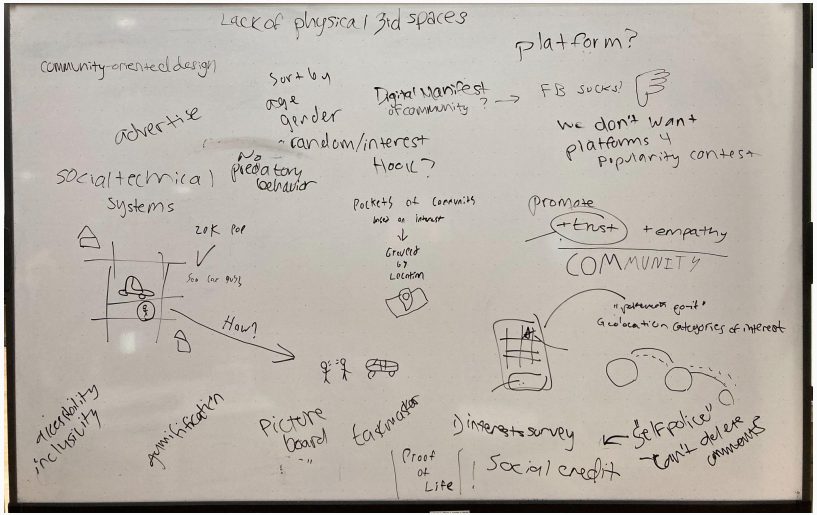
Part 2: Design Overview: ThirdSpace

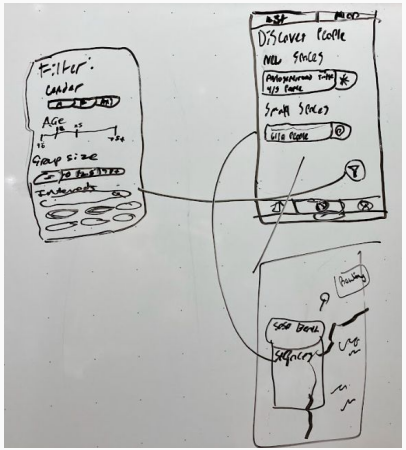
ThirdSpace: A proximity-and-shared-interest platform that lowers the barrier to connection for mobility-limited residents.

- **My role:** Research lead + design contributor, defining the problem, and co-designed the UI in Figma with my partner
- Awarded Best Prototype, MSU 2026 Designathon
- Anchored by the pillars of community, trust and empathy

Design Process
Thesis -> Information Architecture -> Low-fi Wireframes -> Figma Hi-fi

- **Thesis:** A guiding statement to anchor all decisions (developed by Emily Lin's talk + my prior research)
- **IA & Sitemaps:** Used research to group elements, create connections, design coexisting systems
- **Low-fi wireframes:** Sketched core screens; iterated several times on the discover panel
- **High-fi in Figma:** Typography, color, component language, build checklist

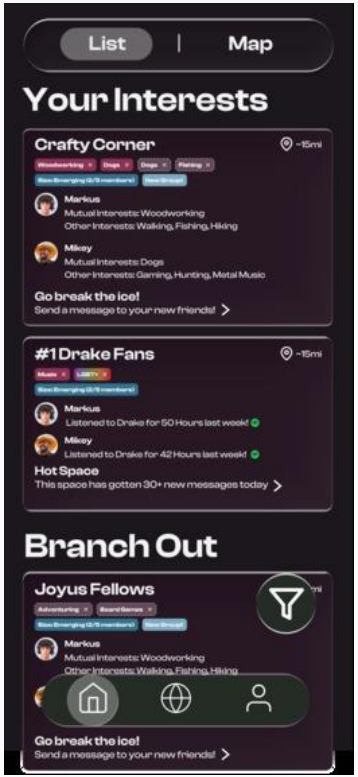




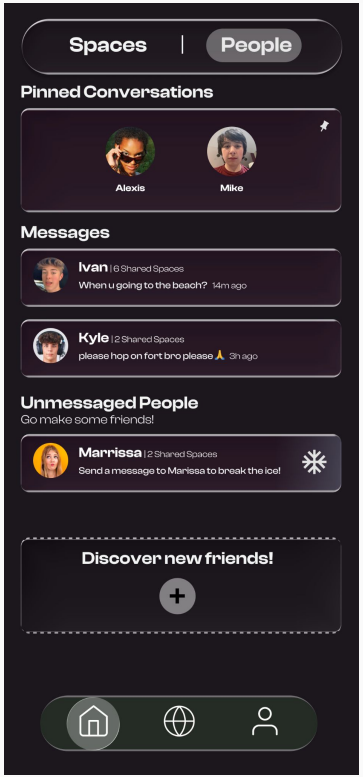
Research -> Design Mapping

Research Finding	Design Implication
Mobility limits access to community spaces	Connect people based on proximity they can actually reach
Residents use digital channels when physical spaces are lacking	A digital platform can fill the gap - but must bridge to real places, not replace them
Storytelling networks form through shared places and group contexts	Design for groups and public spaces, not one-on-one cold introductions
Weak networks reduce belonging and civic engagement	Warm, community-oriented design matters, not transactional matching

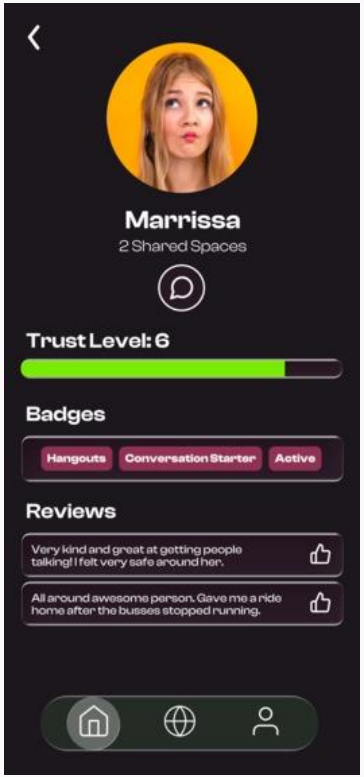
Final Prototype



Screen 1 – Location assignment: randomly assigned nearby public spaces reduce venue pressure.



Screen 2 — Onboarding: interest selection to match users into relevant groups.



Screen 3 — Home feed: shows active groups nearby, nudging toward real-world meetups.



Screen 4 — Proof of life board: users post photos from the assigned location to build trust.

Outcome & Impact

Result: Best Prototype, MSU 2026 Designathon.

Every meaningful design decision traces back to a research finding, the prototype is only as strong as the insight that drove it.

Limitations & Next Steps

- **Survey:** Retrospective design, undergrads recalled high school communities; captures place-based experience but relies on memory.
- **Prototype:** High-fidelity, not shipped; usability testing with target users is the natural next step.
- **Future work:** Test whether ThirdSpace actually increases storytelling network integration and belonging for mobility-limited users.

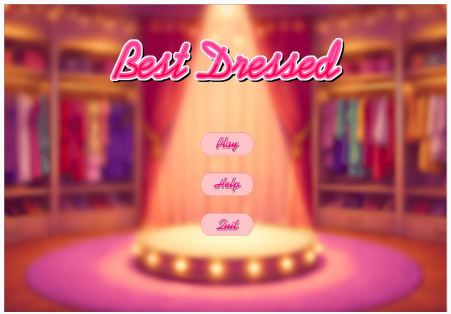
Project 3: Best Dressed - Designing a Branch Decision Experience

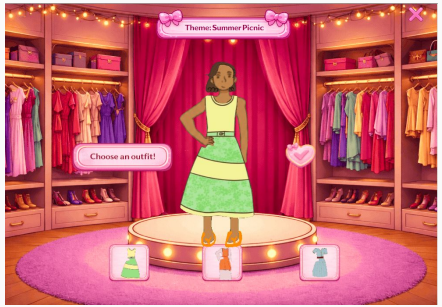
The same question: How do people make choices, and how do we design for those choices, extends beyond civic engagement to any interactive experience.

Best Dressed: An interactive dress-up game built in Python/Pygame, where players choose a skin tone, receive a random theme (wedding, night out, picnic), and make sequential fashion choices - hair shoes, outfit, accessories - each weighted by theme match. A cumulative score determines one of three endings: good, neutral, bad.

Project 3: Best Dressed - Designing a Create-your-own-adventure Game (branch decision experience)

The core mechanic is a decision flow. Each player choice is a node in a branching logic tree with weighted outcomes. Designing the scoring required thinking carefully about user decision flows: how choices build on each other, how feedback signals progress, and how the system stays fair when the theme is randomly assigned.





Best Dressed: Key Design Decisions

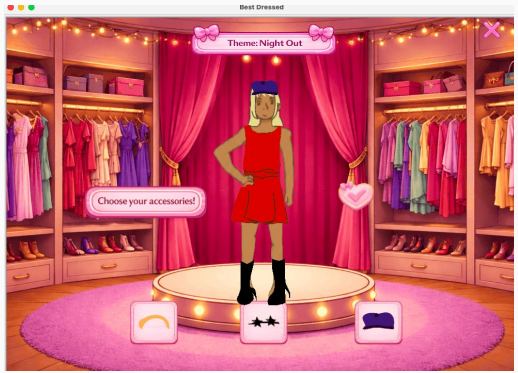
- **Sequential, confirmed choices:** Each selection is confirmed with a checkmark before moving on, users always know where they are in the flow.
- **Visual feedback over text:** Ending scenes use original illustrations to communicate outcome tone, no reliance on text alone. Accessible and immediate.
- **Complete narrative loop:** Start screen -> choices -> intermission -> themed ending with matching audio -> play again to restart with a new random theme. Keeps users engaged, and signals closure.
- **Fairness in randomness:** Because the theme is randomly assigned, scoring weights had to be balanced so every theme felt winnable, a subtle but important UX consideration.

Best Dressed: Process

- **Planning:** Mapped game structure and flow first, themes choices, scoring), before any code was written (1 hr planning session, task breakdown with owners and priorities)
- **Asset creation:** Designed character illustrations, outfits, and ending scenes with a partner; DALLE-E for UI elements and backgrounds.
- **Logic implementation:** Built clickable option system, character layering, weighted scoring, and ending logic in Python/Pygame-CE.
- **Testing & iteration:** Debugged and refined alignment, spacing, and visuals across multiple passes (3 hrs testing + 2 hrs final revisions)

Best Dressed: Outcome

A fully playable desktop game with a branching score system, original character illustrations, themed audio, and three distinct endings. The project demonstrates the full loop of translating a logic structure into a user-facing experience, thinking about how users move through choices, receive feedback, and reach a satisfying conclusion.

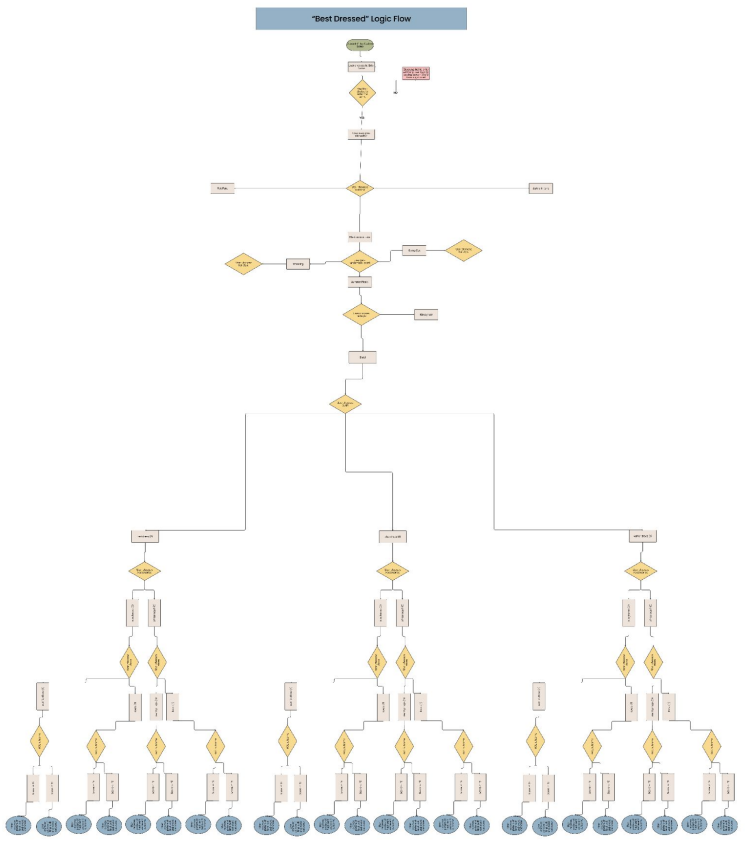




Best Dressed: What This Shows

The scoring logic is, in essence, a user flow map: each choice shapes the outcome, exactly as each design decision shapes a product's experience.

- **Builds as well as researches and designs:** hands-on from logic to UI
- **Collaboration:** Split ownership across assets, logic, and testing with a partner
- **Project planning:** Task breakdown (Kanban boards)with owners, time estimates, and priorities

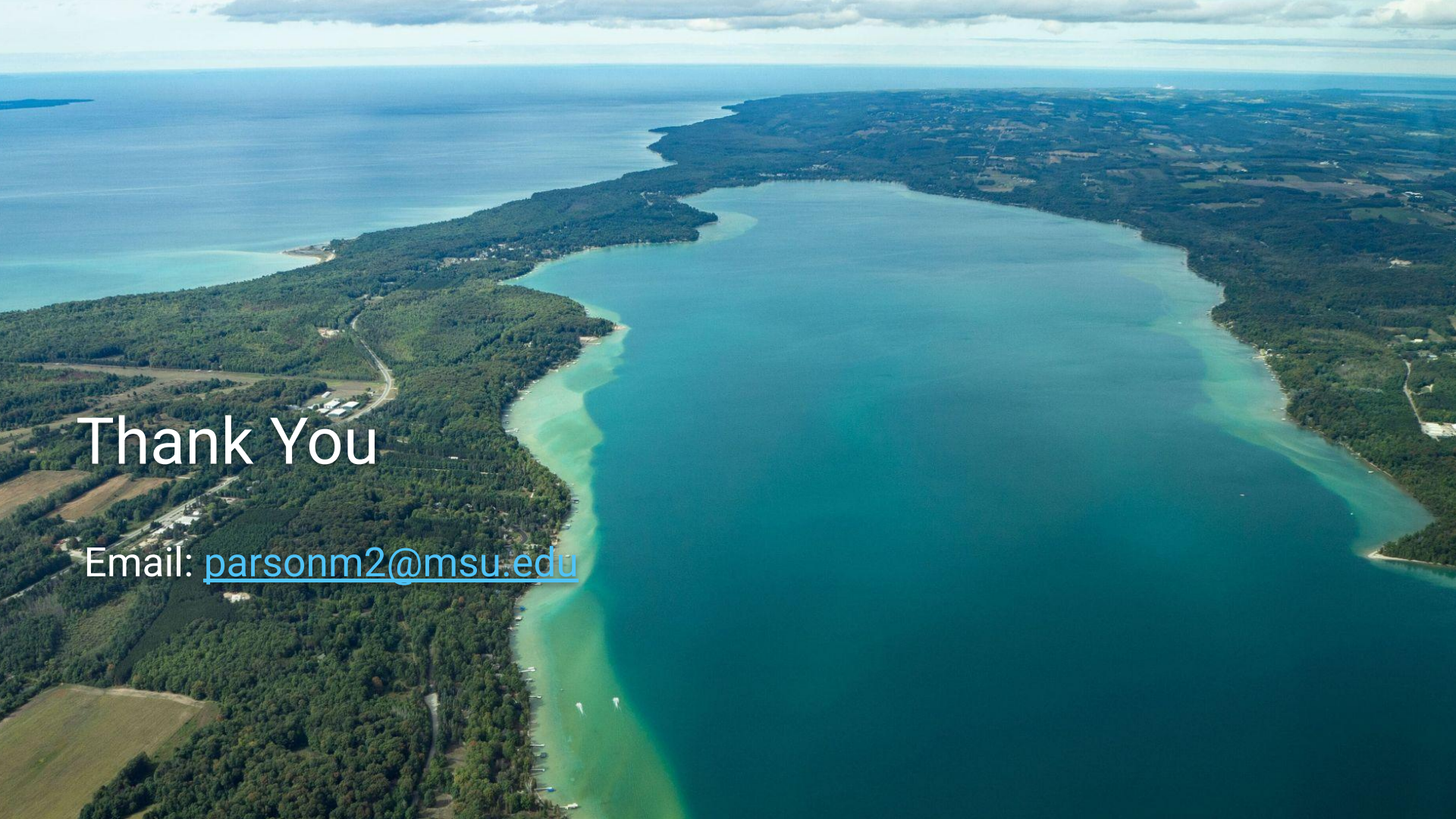


Best Dressed Logic Tree User Flow Diagram

Best Dressed: Limitations & Next Steps

- Built as a class project, so scope was constrained by the assignment (logic tree demonstration) rather than user needs
- No user testing conducted; playtesting would reveal whether scoring felt fair and flow felt intuitive.

  Next steps overall: Usability testing on ThirdSpace; playtesting on Best Dressed; and exploring whether digital community tools actually increase belonging for mobility-limited users.



Thank You

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